

Day 1 — What is Ayurveda? + Swasthya

Module: Ayurveda (Middle) · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students define *Āyurveda* and *Swasthya* and articulate the scope of the framework (lifestyle, prevention, herbal medicine — not surgery or acute care).

Materials

- Whiteboard
- A few sample herbs (turmeric, tulsi if available — check allergies)

Flow

Warm-up (5 min)

Provocation: “If someone said to you ‘what is Ayurveda?’, what would you say in one sentence?”

Take 3 student answers.

Core (25 min)

1. **Etymology:** *āyu* (life, vitality) + *veda* (knowledge, science) = “**the science of life.**” Not just illness — the entire life.
2. **Swasthya** — *swa* (self) + *stha* (established) = “**self-established / situated in oneself.**” A working definition of wellbeing: physical + mental + social balance.
3. **What Ayurveda covers:**
 - Daily routine (*dinacharya*)
 - Seasonal routine (*ritucharya*)
 - Food (*ahāra*) — what, when, how to eat
 - Recreation (*vihāra*) — exercise, sleep, social life
 - Herbal medicines (*aushadhi*)
 - Surgery (*śalya-tantra*) — historically, e.g. Sushruta
 - 8 branches total (the *aṣṭāṅga* of Ayurveda)
4. **What Ayurveda does NOT cover well:**
 - Acute infections requiring antibiotics
 - Emergency surgery
 - Genetic conditions requiring modern diagnostics
 - Mental health requiring specialised psychiatric care

5. **The honest framing:** Ayurveda + modern medicine are *partners*, not rivals. Each has a domain. Don't substitute one for the other.

Activity (10 min) — Map a day

Students fold paper in 4. Label each quadrant: *Sleep, Food, Exercise, Mood*. In each, write what they did yesterday.

Note: “*This is your raw data. Over the next 2 weeks we’ll learn the Ayurvedic framework to make sense of it.*”

Wrap-up (5 min)

- Preview Day 2: “*Tomorrow — the Tridosha. Three biological energies.*”

Homework

- Notice tonight: what time do you go to sleep? What did you eat for dinner? How did you feel after?

Differentiation

- **Tier up:** Read Wujastyk’s intro chapter.
- **Tier down:** Just memorise *Āyurveda* (science of life) and *Swasthya* (wellbeing).

Teacher notes

- The “8 branches” detail is for students who want depth. At Middle band, the 6 mentioned items are enough.
- Watch for students with health conditions — don’t single them out or imply Ayurveda is for them.

Citation(s) used

- vidya-karana RAG cache `day-01-intro.json` for general Ayurveda framing.
- Wujastyk (2003) for scope.